

*From A Window Sill*

Betsy's rings flicker from the patio, up through the fire escape bars, and to our window. Estelle and I kneel on the bed peering out the window. Our favorite show is on at The Brazen Head Tavern. For a Tuesday, it is quite populated. From the third floor, the barflies all buzz as one. Until a single sentence echoes out the brick hollow.

"Fucking Larry." Estelle sighs.

A waitress scurries off.

"Fucking all of them." I huff and puff ashing in a tin candle lid.

A young busboy clears the table while shaking his head. Estelle takes the joint from my hand. The clinking and clanking stops as a new waitress appears from behind. She lines the circular table with long little frosted glasses.

"At least it's beautiful out." I huff.

"And that's just our luck." Estelle smiles back.

I roll my eyes.

"It's not the lights or even the noise." Estelle fumes. "It's just the constant confirmation that." She pauses and stares at the eldest man. I raise an eyebrow.

She looks at me and rolls her eyes. Estelle turns on the bed, and spreads on her knees. She pretends to lure in an imaginary creature while keeping the joint behind her back. Smoke rises above her head making crescent moons. I get on all fours and crawl over, placing my head in her lap. Estelle puts the joint in my mouth.

"Sit with it." She says.

I cough uncontrollably. Estelle doesn't look down. Our co-workers don't look up. Rather, all take a shot. Only Betsy, with her cute shoes, watches in disgust. The rest slam down their glasses already asking for more. Estelle's eyes say the same.

"I give her three months, tops." Estelle points at Betsy.

“I kind of want to text her.” I say.

Estelle shakes her head.

The oldest man turns and hooks his finger in the air. He wiggles it at a waitress folding silverware. She nods and darts to the back.

“Watch this.” Estelle winks at me.

I look at her arms. Her wrists are so thin. Cold blue lines cut through her like shears through milkweed. Her tendons suddenly bulge.

She flicks the glowing roach directly up. My eyes widen as it hangs in front of the street light. It tumbles backwards in perfect little cartwheels. Miraculously, passing through the three floors of cracks.

“Plop”

I imagine I hear the sizzle as it lands in the oldest man’s beer. A few drops hit Betsy’s hand. She eyes the beer and looks up. I freeze. Estelle is too busy watching Fucking Larry to see we’ve been spotted. Betsy, however, blinks, and continues sitting in silence.

Below, the men sweat in their silk suits. The women fidget at their a-line skirts. The oldest man swigs the rest of his beer. It falls like a virgin into a volcano. I hear him gulp. Finished, he places the glass upside down, belches, and wiggles his crooked little finger once again. Betsy upper-left lip rises.

“Do you think he’ll get sick?” I ask Estelle while pouring tea.

“I don’t think he’ll get any better.” She takes a sip of chrysanthemum. It’s bright, gold, and clear.

“That’s my wedding ring.” The oldest man says. “I shouldn’t even.”

I turn to watch. Betsy looks absolutely bored. Estelle grabs my hand and places it on her throat.

“Please.” She laughs. “It’s easier than hearing this shit.”

The oldest man smiles as another round is placed down. Betsy’s glances up, catching my eyes for the second time tonight. The crowd’s roar grows.

Only Betsy and I are quiet. Even Estelle is going on about something. The old man places his hand on Betsy’s thigh. She calmly looks down and removes it like a used napkin. Before he can react, she pulls out a silver cigarette holder. Everyone is looking at her now. She smiles.

Betsy lights up, passing the case around. They murmur about engravings and quality. She blows up smoke rings and pulls through her nose. After finishing, she smoothly turns to get up. As her hand passes the oldest man’s beer, there’s a quick little tilt. It lasts for less than a second.

The ring on her pinky hinges open. The moon reflects a half gram of fine white powder pouring. It disappears into the beer.

Estelle is still talking. She keeps pointing at the few stars she can see. She’s going on about some seven sisters being chased by Hercules. The waitress comes with more little glasses. Betsy takes one, raises it, and initiates a group cheer. They all drink.

Betsy looks up at me. She places her index finger on her lips and blows up a kiss. She gets up and walks into the bar. The oldest man finishes his beer. He just pours it down his throat like throwing a child down a well. He slams this glass too. The buzzer begins to ring.

